All that changed the moment Modi entered the studio in his blue jacket kurta. As soon as Rajat called out his name, the studio audience went wild. They began chanting his name in a crazed manner. One of the girls even shouted, ‘Modi, I love you!’, at which the prime ministerial candidate burst out laughing. Says Rajat, ‘I had done hundreds of *Aap ki Adalat*s but had never seen anything remotely like this. Even film stars like Salman and Shahrukh had not got this kind of a frenzied response.’

The audience was predominantly north Indian urban middle class—housewives and college students, government clerks and traders. It was just the kind of urban constituency that was driving the Modi juggernaut. ‘We had asked all our staff members to bring their friends and relatives because we knew the programme would start late and we needed the audience to stay till it was over,’ says Rajat.

Modi was transformed once the cameras turned on. The palpable adulation of the audience was his tonic and the long day on the campaign trail was forgotten. He was now Modi, the consummate stage performer, acting before an adoring audience. This is what he had learnt in his early days of theatre in Vadnagar—gauging the mood of the audience, knowing when to raise them to a fever pitch, when to dissolve them into laughter. Modi understands all this well and plays an audience like a conductor leads an orchestra.

He was serious and witty in equal measure. The one-liners just kept coming. When Rajat asked why he didn’t wear a topi offered to him by a Muslim religious leader, Modi shot back, ‘Have you ever seen Gandhi and Sardar wear a topi?’ When asked about his anti-minority image, he claimed, ‘I want Muslims to have a Koran in one hand and a computer in another.’ When told that Azam Khan, the SP leader, had called him the ‘elder brother of puppies’, he replied, ‘I say thank you very much because the loyalty of dogs is unparalleled.’

Every answer was met with rapturous applause and loud cries of ‘Modi, Modi!’ For a viewer, it seemed as though one had been transported to a BJP rally. This was a master communicator in total command, pulling off yet another virtuoso solo act. The recording went on for almost ninety minutes,